reliance on China.[83] Giving Nepal access to Chinese sea and road infrastructure for third-country trade, the transport and transit deal significantly reduces Nepal's need to engage with India. Another important component is the Nepal–China Trans-Himalayan Multi-dimensional Connectivity Network, which includes the Nepal–China cross-border railway. From the Indian side, however, concerns also relate to the potential debt issues that may arise from Chinese investments in India's neigh-bouring countries. Indian criticism that the BRI could evolve into "debt traps" has resonated with the United States and Japan.

India has long been concerned with Chinese technological support to Pakistan, particularly nuclear and ballistic missile transfers. Significantly, Pakistan has been China's main recipient of arms for the last three decades, accounting for 37 percent of China's total arms exports between 2014 and 2018.[84] Given Indian concern over China's footprint in South Asia, India will likely also view warily the increased Chinese presence in Afghanistan and Central Asia that the BRI will bring. As one of the world's largest importers of oil and gas, India wants access to the oil and gas resources in Iran, Central Asia, and the Caspian region. Potential Chinese domination in Afghanistan, Pakistan, and Iran would therefore constitute a considerable challenge to Indian security policy. In April 2016, the Modi government finalised the trilateral Chabahar agreement with Iran and Afghanistan; this will improve regional connectivity and make Chabahar Port in Iran a key location.[85] Thus India's geopolitical rivalry with China in South Asia is reflected within the economic, diplomatic, strategic, and military spheres and seems very much alive. In the following, I elaborate on how this rivalry plays out in the maritime domain.